

COPA

The Comprehensive Outdoor Playspace Audit Tool

A Brand & Storytelling Memo for the Public-Facing Surfaces

A design document for the landing page, about page, documentation, sign-up flow, and the language the product speaks to its users in.

Why this document exists

Inside the product — the dashboard, the audit form, the report view — design freedom is constrained. The screens have to display data, and data has shape, and shape has rules. The product UI can be polished, but its job is functional clarity above all else.

The marketing and learning surfaces are the opposite. They have no data to display. They are entirely a question of: *what story do we tell, and how do we tell it?*

This is where this product can feel like itself. This is where we can communicate that what users do matters, that the work is grounded in real research, that the tool was made by people who care. The design of these surfaces is not decoration around the product — it *is* a substantial part of the product, because it is where users decide whether to trust the work they are being asked to do, and how to feel about doing it.

This memo is the foundation. Before any landing page wireframe, any documentation theme, any sign-up form, the team should be aligned on what follows.

Part One — Foundation

What this brand is, in one sentence

COPA — the Comprehensive Outdoor Playspace Audit Tool — is an instrument for the careful field observation of children’s outdoor playspaces, made for the practitioners who do that work.

Read that sentence again. Notice what isn’t in it. There is no “AI-powered.” No “platform.” No “revolutionize” or “modern” or “next-generation.” No implied promise of speed or scale or efficiency. The sentence is a description, not a claim. That is on purpose, and it is the entire point.

The product cannot make grand promises because the work it serves is quiet. A researcher walks through a playground in Cork or Göteborg or Ithaca. They observe. They record what they see, structured by an instrument that has been peer-reviewed and refined through years of fieldwork. Their observations

contribute to studies that will, eventually, shape decisions about what kinds of places children are given to play in. That is the work. The tool's job is to serve it without getting in the way.

A brand built around this work cannot speak in startup voice. It would be tonally wrong, like wearing a baseball cap to a research symposium. The brand has to match the seriousness of what it serves — without becoming stuffy, institutional, or self-important about it.

Who we speak to

Three audiences, with overlapping but distinct needs:

The researcher. Academic. Probably an occupational therapist, environmental psychologist, urban planner, or play studies scholar. They care about methodological rigor, the citation trail, who developed the instrument and how. They are reading the marketing pages skeptically, looking for the evidence that this is serious work.

The practitioner manager. Could be running a parks department, a non-profit, a municipal play strategy. They have programs to administer, auditors to coordinate, reports to produce. They care about whether this will actually work for their team, whether it produces credible data, and whether it will respect their auditors' time.

The auditor. The person who will actually walk through the playspace with this tool. They might be a graduate student, a trained surveyor, a community advocate, a designer doing a site analysis. They care about whether the tool will treat them as a professional doing skilled work, or as a data-entry worker filling out forms.

The marketing surfaces have to speak to all three at once, without flattening any of them. The researcher should feel the rigor. The manager should feel the practicality. The auditor should feel the respect.

What we are not

We are not a SaaS productivity tool. We do not save people time. The work takes the time it takes. A careful audit is not faster than a careless one.

We are not a children's brand. The product is *about* children's play, but it is not made *for* children. Bright primary colors, rounded illustrations, pictures of kids holding hands — these would be tonally disastrous. The audience is adult professionals doing serious work.

We are not an academic publication. The instrument is published research, but the product is software in active use. The brand should feel contemporary and warm, not like a 1990s university website.

We are not an institution. We are not the IPCC. We are not WHO. We are a small, careful piece of software made in collaboration with a research team. We should be appropriately modest about that.

We are not a typical “tech” product. We are not selling speed, automation, intelligence, or scale. Those words don’t apply. We are selling care.

Part Two — Voice

The tone, in three words

Considered. Earnest. Specific.

Considered means every word has been thought about. Nothing is filler, nothing is hype, nothing is reaching. The voice is calm because it doesn’t need to perform.

Earnest means we genuinely believe what we are saying. We are not ironic about the work. We are not performatively humble. We say what we mean, plainly, and we mean it.

Specific means we name actual things. The PVUA instrument. The researchers behind it. The five domains. The 37 questions. We do not abstract the product into “audit experiences” or “play assessment solutions.” We use the words a practitioner would use.

Language patterns to use

Use the names of things. “The Play Value and Usability Audit instrument, developed by Morgenthaler, Loebach, Lynch, Pentland, Kottorp, and Schulze.” Not “our research-backed methodology.”

Use real numbers. “37 items across 5 domains, organized into the COPA instrument.” Not “comprehensive coverage.”

Use concrete verbs. “Walk through the site. Record what you observe.” Not “Capture insights with our intuitive workflow.”

Acknowledge the work. “An audit takes about an hour. Most of that is walking and looking, not entering data.” This communicates respect — we know what the work actually is.

Cite when you can. “Morgenthaler, T. et al. (2024). *Using the theory of affordance to understand environment-play transactions*. American Journal of Occupational Therapy.” A citation in the right place is a trust signal worth more than ten paragraphs of marketing copy.

Language patterns to avoid

Anything that ends in “-ize” or “-ify” — modernize, optimize, simplify, streamline. These verbs assume the user wants to do less of something. Auditors want to do their work *well*, not less of it.

Adverbs of intensity — easily, quickly, instantly, seamlessly, effortlessly. The work is not effortless. Pretending it is insults the practitioner.

The word “platform.” It is a tool. Or an instrument. Or, at most, a system. “Platform” is corporate language for “thing that does many things,” which is the opposite of what this product is.

The phrase “powered by.” Especially “AI-powered.” We are not powered by anything except the practitioners who use us.

Superlatives without evidence. No “best,” “most comprehensive,” “most trusted,” “leading.” If we made claims like that, the researcher reading our about page would close the tab.

Sentimental copy about children. No “every child deserves.” No “creating brighter futures.” No “where memories are made.” This is condescending to both the audience and the children. The work does what it does; we don’t need to dress it up.

Voice in practice — examples

A button label, in the wrong voice: **“Get started — it’s free!”** The same button, in our voice: **“Begin”**

A page heading, wrong: **“Revolutionize your playspace audits.”** Right: **“For evaluating outdoor playspaces.”**

A product introduction, wrong: **“Welcome to the future of playspace assessment.”** Right: **“COPA. An instrument for the careful field observation of children’s outdoor playspaces.”**

An empty state, wrong: **“No audits yet — let’s create your first one!”** Right: **“No submitted audits yet. They will appear here once auditors complete their first session.”**

A confirmation, wrong: **“ Audit submitted successfully!”** Right: **“Your audit has been received.”**

An error, wrong: **“Oops! Something went wrong. Please try again.”** Right: **“The connection didn’t go through. Your work is saved on this device, and we’ll sync it once the network returns.”**

Notice that the right versions are not colder. They are warmer, because they are honest. The wrong versions are pretending to feel things on the user’s behalf. The right versions trust the user with the actual situation.

Part Three — The Visual World

The metaphor

The visual identity is built around one metaphor: **the field notebook**.

Think of a leather-covered Moleskine carried by a researcher walking through a park. Pen marks. Pressed-flat pages. The smell of warm paper. A few pages with sketches. Most pages with careful handwriting. Margins with notes. A book that has been *used*.

That is the texture we are reaching for. Not the literal aesthetic of a field notebook (we are not making a skeuomorphic interface), but the *feeling* of one. Warm. Touched. Considered. Made by someone who does this work themselves.

This metaphor governs everything else.

The palette

Cream as the canvas. A warm off-white — #f8f5f0 or thereabouts — that suggests aged paper without being precious about it. This is the default background everywhere. Not pure white (too clinical), not gray (too corporate), not yellow (too saturated). A specific warm neutral.

Ink as the text. A warm near-black — #1c1814 — that has a slight brown cast, so it never reads as cold. Black ink on cream paper.

One accent color: terracotta. A warm earth-tone orange — #b06a3a — used very sparingly. For the active link. For the primary button. For the underline beneath the section being read. Almost nowhere else. The accent’s job is to mark attention, not to brand. When you see it, it means *here*.

Two contextual colors used only for data: moss green for completed work, a muted amber for warnings. These appear inside the product, on report pages, in score displays. Not in the marketing copy, not in headings, not as decorative elements.

That is the entire palette. Five colors total. No gradients. No backgrounds. No “fun” tertiary colors. The discipline is the point.

The typography

Display: an editorial serif. Specifically Instrument Serif, or a similar quiet display serif. *Not* Playfair Display (too theatrical), not EB Garamond (too academic). Something with character but restraint — the typeface of a thoughtful magazine, not a wedding invitation.

The serif gives every page warmth and a hint of literary credibility. It signals that words have been chosen carefully. Used at large sizes (36–60px) for page titles, section headings, pull quotes.

Body: a humanist sans-serif. DM Sans, Söhne, or Inter Display. Comfortable to read at length. Slightly warmer than Helvetica, slightly more refined than Arial. Used at 15–17px for body, 13–14px for UI.

Monospace: IBM Plex Mono. For citations, codes, IDs, occasional inline code in documentation. Sparingly.

No decorative type. No script fonts. No display fonts beyond the single editorial serif. No experimental anything. The typographic restraint is what makes the design feel adult.

The imagery

This is where many products in this space go wrong. They use stock photos of children laughing on swings. We will not.

The dominant imagery is of place, not people. Photographs of empty playgrounds at golden hour. The texture of a rubber surface. A close crop of a climbing structure. The shadow of a swing on the ground. The way a path curves around a tree.

These photographs evoke *the work* — the playspace as the object of study. The viewer (who is a practitioner) places themselves into the scene. They imagine walking through.

When people appear in imagery, they appear in the act of working. An auditor with a tablet, photographed from behind, looking at a slide structure. Hands writing in a field notebook. A researcher pointing at something out of frame. The face is rarely the focus; the work is.

No stock photography. The imagery should be commissioned or sourced from the research team’s actual fieldwork. Real sites, real researchers. The provenance should be cited in small captions.

Halftone treatment for any decorative imagery. When a photograph is used as background or atmosphere, it gets a halftone or duotone treatment in the brand colors. This unifies disparate sources and gives them the texture of printed editorial material.

The logo and wordmark

The wordmark is the four-letter acronym set in the editorial serif, italicized, with the period at the end as a small accent in terracotta. The period is the brand’s quietest signature: a stop, a pause, a settled finality.

COPA.

Four characters in Instrument Serif Italic, with one terracotta dot at the end. It will work as a header logo, a favicon, a stamp on a PDF report cover, an embossed seal at the bottom of a research publication. It is short enough to be a strong typographic mark and meaningful enough to be ownable.

The full expansion — *Comprehensive Outdoor Playspace Audit Tool* — appears once on the landing page, in the about page citation, and in the introduction of any formal document. Otherwise the product refers to itself simply as **COPA** or **the COPA tool**. Repeating the full name everywhere makes a brand feel like a government agency. We use the acronym the way researchers use *PVUA* in their papers: once for introduction, then as the working noun.

Beyond the wordmark, any iconographic mark should:

- Be a single color, not a gradient
- Work at 16px and at 200px equally well
- Have one specific reading — not be open to interpretation
- Be derived from something real to the work, not abstract decoration

Directions worth exploring for an icon mark to accompany the wordmark: a simplified line drawing of a path through a space (the auditor’s route); a stamp-like seal suggesting methodological rigor; an abstracted compass point (orienting in the field). The wordmark alone is also sufficient — many serious instruments don’t need a separate icon. *Concorde* didn’t have a mascot. Neither does *The Lancet*.

Part Four — The Surfaces

This is page-by-page guidance. Not implementation specs — those come later. This is the design *thinking* for each surface: what it does, what arc it follows, what mood it produces.

The landing page

The landing page has one job: convince the practitioner that this product is worth their attention. It is not a sales page. There is no “buy now.” There is barely a CTA. Its job is to build trust.

The arc:

1. **A single line.** At the top of the page, occupying enough vertical space to demand attention. “*For evaluating outdoor playspaces.*” No exclamation, no claim, no “powered by.” A description. The reader should immediately understand what this is for.
2. **A short paragraph.** Two or three sentences naming what the product does and who it is for. Names COPA. Mentions the PVUA instrument by name. Mentions that it is implemented from peer-reviewed research.

3. **The work.** A section that describes the audit experience from the auditor’s perspective. Not the product’s features — the work’s shape. “An audit takes about an hour. Most of it is walking and looking. The instrument has 37 items across 5 domains, completed on a phone or tablet, in any condition of network connectivity. When you submit, your observations become a structured report.”
4. **The provenance.** A section titled simply *About the instrument*. Names the researchers. Cites the publications. Links to the American Journal of Occupational Therapy paper. This section is small, quiet, and devastatingly credible. It tells the skeptical academic reader that they can stop looking for the catch.
5. **For each persona, briefly.** *For managers. For auditors. For researchers.* Three short paragraphs, each two sentences. Each one describes what the product does for that persona, in their language.
6. **Begin.** A single button. Not “Sign up free.” Not “Get started today.” Just *Begin*. The act of beginning is what we are inviting.

The page should be read as a single document, top to bottom, in five minutes. It should not be a long-scroll marketing page with parallax sections. It should be a memo.

Visual character: Cream canvas. Editorial serif title at the top. Generous whitespace. One photograph, possibly halftoned, somewhere in the middle — a real playspace, captioned with a real location and a real photographer. The terracotta accent appears exactly twice on the page: in the wordmark period, and in the *Begin* button.

The about page

If the landing page is a memo, the about page is an essay.

This page tells the story of the PVUA instrument and the team behind it. It is where the researcher reader spends the most time. It should reward that time.

Sections, narratively:

The instrument’s origin. How the PVUA came to be. The collaboration between Cornell, Ireland, and Sweden. The systematic literature review. The expert panel. The years of field testing. This should read like a piece of nonfiction — a paragraph or two of actual prose, not bullets.

The team. Photographs and short bios of the researchers, in chronological order of involvement. Each name links to their faculty page. Specifies their institution and discipline. The reader should finish this section knowing who built this work.

The fieldwork. A map (not a flashy interactive one — a simple, beautifully-typeset world map) showing the sites where the instrument has been tested.

Cork. Stockholm. Ithaca. Whatever else applies. Each site is a small dot with a hover label.

The publications. A list — not bullet-pointed, but typeset like a references section in a journal. Hanging indents. Italicized titles. Volume and page numbers. This is the section that ends any remaining doubt about the work’s seriousness.

Where it goes from here. A single short paragraph about ongoing development. Honest. “The instrument continues to be refined. The software is in active development. We’re working on translations into French and Mandarin. Field reports continue to inform iteration.”

The about page can be longer than the landing page. It can be read as an essay. The visual character is similar to the landing page but with more ink — denser typesetting, more text, fewer images. It is a *piece of writing*, presented well.

The sign-up flow

Most sign-up flows are forms. Ours is a welcome.

Page one — The frame. A single sentence: “*Joining as a manager, an auditor, or a researcher?*” Three rectangles below it, each containing a one-sentence description of that role and what they will do in the system. The user clicks one. The choice matters because each path is different.

Page two — The minimum needed. Email address. Name. Institution (optional). Nothing else. No marketing checkboxes. No “how did you hear about us.” No phone number. The friction is the friction of reading a paragraph carefully, not of filling in fields.

Page three — The welcome. After submission, a screen that says, in serif at large size: “*Welcome to the network of practitioners.*” A short paragraph. A button to enter the product.

The phrase *network of practitioners* is doing important work here. The user is not creating an account. They are joining something. The phrasing matters because the feeling matters.

The documentation

Documentation is for users in the middle of trying to do something. The design should respect that they are *in the middle of something*. They are not browsing for entertainment.

Layout: A wide reading column (700–800px max), a narrow sidebar with table of contents on the left, navigation breadcrumbs at the top. Background cream, text dark ink, code in IBM Plex Mono on a slightly darker cream tint. This is a manual. It should look like one.

Voice: Procedural and patient. “*To start an audit, navigate to the Auditor workspace and select a place from your assigned list. The audit session will*

resume from where you last left it, including answers recorded offline.” Not enthusiastic. Not performatively friendly. Helpful.

Examples in real terms: Code samples and screenshots use real research scenarios. A worked example of running an audit at “Stewart Park Inclusive Playground in Ithaca.” Not “Sample Place A” or “Lorem Ipsum Park.”

The methodology guide. A specific section of the docs that lays out the PVUA instrument in detail. The five domains. The 37 items. The scoring rubrics. This section is treated almost like a print appendix in a research paper — typeset with care, including the original item language verbatim, with citations.

How-to guides for auditors

Distinct from the docs. The docs are reference material. The how-to guides are training material. They teach a craft.

These should feel like reading a chapter from a thoughtful manual — the way the Audubon Society writes its bird identification guides, or the way orienteering instructors write their training texts. The reader is not being marketed to; they are being *taught*.

Structure of a how-to guide:

A short framing paragraph. *“This guide walks through preparing for a field audit. It assumes you have already been assigned at least one place. It takes about ten minutes to read. Read it once before your first audit; you will not need to read it again.”*

Step-by-step instructions, numbered, with screenshots embedded as needed. Screenshots are simple — no annotations on top, no big red arrows. The screenshot is shown, captioned, and the next paragraph explains what to look at.

A *Notes from experienced auditors* section at the end of each guide. Two or three short tips, attributed to specific people. *“Janet from the Ithaca team always brings a portable battery. The app works offline, but the phone still drains.”* These notes give the practitioner the feeling of joining a community of careful workers.

The in-product language (storybook)

Every word inside the product is part of the brand. The voice has to extend through the dashboard, the audit form, the empty states, the errors. This is where many products with good marketing surfaces fall apart — the home page is poetry, but the buttons inside still say “Submit” and the empty states still say “No items yet.”

Principles for in-product copy:

Acknowledge the reality. If the user is offline, say so plainly. If something is saving, say it is saving. If something failed, say what failed and what the user can do.

Use the language the user uses. “Audit” not “form submission.” “Place” not “record.” “Domain” not “category.” “Auditor” not “user.”

Avoid system voice. The product should not refer to itself in the third person (“The system has saved your data”) or first-person plural (“We’ve saved your work”). It should be quiet about itself: “Saved.” “Saving locally.” “Saved to server.”

Use whitespace. Empty states, modal confirmations, error pages — all should have generous whitespace, like the marketing pages do. The silence is part of the voice.

A few specific copy examples:

Where	Avoid	Use
Empty audit list	“No audits yet! Get started by creating one.”	“You haven’t started any COPA audits yet.”
Save indicator	“ Saved successfully!”	“Saved.”
Offline notice	“ You’re offline!”	“Working offline. Your audit is being saved on this device.”
Submit button	“Submit Audit”	“Submit”
Submission confirmation	“ Audit submitted!”	“Your audit has been received.”
Error toast	“An error occurred. Please try again.”	“Something didn’t connect. Try again, or come back when you’re online.”
Field validation	“This field is required”	“Required”
Logout confirmation	“Are you sure you want to logout?”	“Sign out?”

The pattern: shorter, plainer, more honest. The user is treated like an intelligent adult who is in the middle of doing important work.

Part Five — Anti-Patterns

A short list of things that would destroy this brand if introduced. Worth keeping nearby during any design review.

Stock photography of children. Inappropriate to the audience and tonally infantilizing. Imagery is of place, not children.

Gradients. No background gradients, no button gradients. Flat solid color is the only treatment. A gradient feels like a 2018 startup.

The word “platform.” Use “tool,” “instrument,” “system,” or “product.” Never “platform.”

Marketing buzzwords. “Streamline,” “supercharge,” “next-generation,” “AI-powered,” “best-in-class,” “leading,” “world-class.” None of these words have any specific meaning. Replace with the actual specific thing you mean.

Emojis in UI copy. No celebration confetti, no checkmark emojis in toasts, no warning sirens in error states. The product is text. Text does the work.

Three-column “feature” grids. The bane of SaaS landing pages. Three icons, three headings, three paragraphs. Every product has them. Ours will not. Use prose, or use specifics, or use nothing.

Testimonial quotes from anonymous job titles. *“This product changed how we work. — Director of Operations, Fortune 500 Company.”* If we have testimonials, they are from named researchers at named institutions, with their actual face and their actual quote. Otherwise we have no testimonials.

Generic dashboard screenshots in marketing. Showing the dashboard on the landing page is a tell that we don’t trust the writing. The writing should carry the page.

“Coming soon” sections. If a feature isn’t ready, it isn’t on the site. We don’t put placeholders for things we haven’t built.

Closing note

This document is meant to outlast any specific implementation. The landing page will be redesigned eventually. The documentation site will be migrated. The illustrations will be commissioned and re-commissioned. The voice will hold across all of those changes — if we keep returning to this memo.

The single most important thing in this document is the orientation. This brand serves the work, not the product. Auditors walking through playgrounds, recording careful observations, contributing to research that will eventually make a real difference in the kinds of places children get to play. That is the thing. The website, the dashboard, the documentation — all of it is in service of that.

If a future design decision is in doubt, the test is: does this make the practitioner feel respected? Does this make the work feel dignified? Does this make the careful eye feel seen?

If yes, ship it. If no, redesign it.